NORTH CURRENT
Fact-check column, October 2026

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Slug: FACTCHECK MONARCHS

Head: # Fact check: Did monarchs crash 90 percent this year?

Dek: *The 90 percent figure is real, but it measures nearly three decades of decline in the monarchs' winter colonies in Mexico. This winter's count hasn't been made yet.*

Rating: **Misleading**

Art: Chart of the winter counts, data in source 1. USFWS tagging photo, credit U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service.

By Owen Brandt
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About 530 words, plus sources

The claim: A post making the rounds this month says monarch butterflies crashed 90 percent this year. Comment after comment under it says the same thing: not a single monarch in the yard all summer.

Where the 90 comes from: Minnesota's monarchs belong to the eastern population, which spends the winter packed into fir forests high in the mountains of central Mexico. Each winter, researchers with WWF Mexico and Mexico's national protected-areas agency measure how much forest the colonies cover. The biggest count on record came in the winter of 1996-97, when they covered about 18 hectares, roughly 45 acres. In 2013-14, and again in 2023-24, they covered less than one hectare.

Measured against that peak, those winters were down about 95 percent. Conservation groups used a 90 percent figure in a 2014 petition asking the federal government to protect the monarch, and it has circulated ever since. It is a real number. It describes a decline over nearly three decades, not a single season.

This year: The count for the coming winter doesn't exist yet. The colonies are usually measured in December, once the butterflies have settled in, and the result comes out early the next year. No one has a 90 percent figure for 2026, or any figure. This may turn out to be a poor year. No one can say that yet, either.

What a yard can tell you: An empty yard is real to the person watching it, but it is not a population count. Monarchs follow milkweed and weather. A dry summer, a cold spring or strong winds during the migration can change where females lay their eggs and when the

butterflies pass through. A thin summer in one region can sit next to a decent one somewhere else.

The people who track monarchs through the summer don't rely on chance sightings. The Monarch Larva Monitoring Project, which began at the University of Minnesota in 1997, has volunteers count eggs and caterpillars on the same milkweed patches week after week.

The year-to-year picture: The winter counts swing a lot. The colonies grew to about 6 hectares in 2018-19, the most in more than a decade, then shrank by more than half the next winter. They fell to 0.9 hectare in 2023-24, then roughly doubled the winter after. Weather on the breeding grounds and along the migration drives much of that. None of the swings, up or down, has reversed the long-term decline.

What is behind the decline: Researchers point to several causes at once: the loss of milkweed, the only plants monarch caterpillars eat, from farm fields and roadsides; pesticides; logging and other damage to the winter forests in Mexico; and more extreme weather. In December 2024, the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service proposed listing the monarch as a threatened species under the Endangered Species Act, citing many of the same threats.

Rating: Misleading. Monarchs are in real long-term trouble, and the 90 percent figure has a basis. Pinning it on this year turns a decline measured over nearly three decades into a one-year crash that no one has measured. The winter count due early next year will say how this season went.

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SOURCES

1. WWF Mexico and Mexico's National Commission of Natural Protected Areas: area of forest occupied by overwintering monarch colonies, by winter, 1993-94 to the most recent survey. This is the series for the chart.
2. U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service: monarch butterfly species status assessment, and the proposed rule to list the monarch as threatened, December 2024.
3. The 2014 petition asking the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service to protect the monarch under the Endangered Species Act.
4. Monarch Larva Monitoring Project: monitoring methods and summer data.
5. Monarch Joint Venture: status summaries for the eastern monarch population.